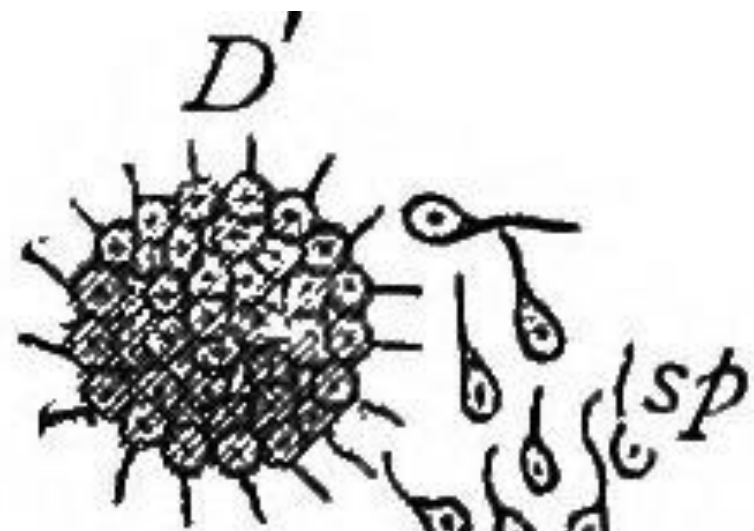
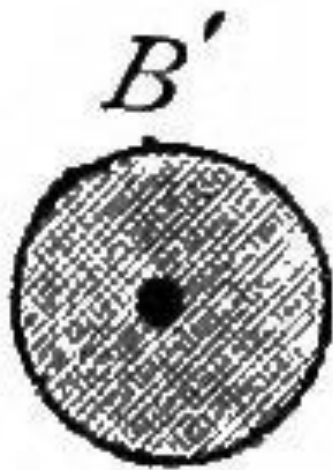




CONCEPTION, PREGNANCY & BIRTH

NURSE 280 MAY 21, 2026



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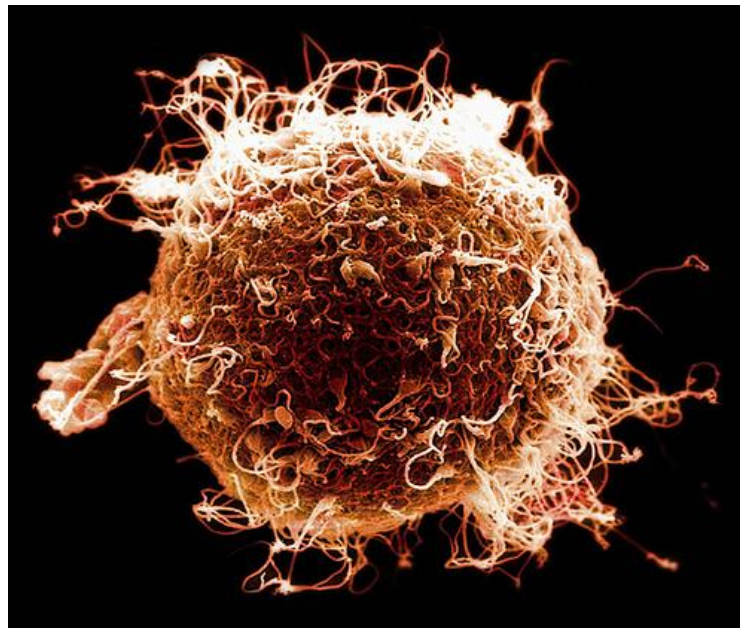
HOW DOES PREGNANCY HAPPEN?

Pregnancy



THE MOMENT OF CONCEPTION

- Typically takes place high in the **Fallopian tube**, mid-cycle
- Approximately **1000 sperm** will reach the ovum
- Sperm can live **5-7 days** in the vaginal tract
- Egg and sperm do not always combine, even when they meet
- Once conception is successful, **implantation** can take another 2 weeks
- Though people have a range of beliefs about when life begins, we say someone is “pregnant” once implantation occurs



PREGNANCY CHALLENGES

- **40 - 50%** of pregnancies are unplanned in Canada
- Fertility changes over the lifespan, particularly for people who can get pregnant
- About **15%** of couples attempting to conceive face fertility challenges
- Infertility testing and surgery are covered by provincial medical plans; most cover *some* fertility treatments (not AB or SK)
- **IVF, surrogacy, adoption** are some available alternatives
- **Miscarriages** are common, especially in the first 7 weeks of pregnancy, but are rarely discussed
- **Ectopic** pregnancies occur outside the uterus (usually in the fallopian tube)



PREGNANCY STAGES

Typical gestation period is 280 days (**40 weeks**, or ten lunar months); most babies are born within 10 days of their due date (37 weeks is considered 'term', while 42 weeks is 'post dates').

First trimester:

- period of rapid development; major organs form; critical period of vulnerability

Second trimester:

- fetus reaches viability by the end

Third trimester:

- fetus is usually 'head down' and drops lower in the pelvis before birth



Medical illustration by Chidiebere Ibe

BIRTH

- Loss of plug or 'bloody show'
- Rupture of amniotic sac ('water breaks')
- Contractions
- Labour:

STAGE ONE (12-24 hours)

- cervix dilates and effaces
- contractions become more frequent and stronger
- ends with transition as the baby's head moves into vagina

STAGE TWO (minutes-hours)

- contractions move the baby down the vagina
- baby 'crowns'
- stage ends when baby emerges from the vagina

STAGE THREE

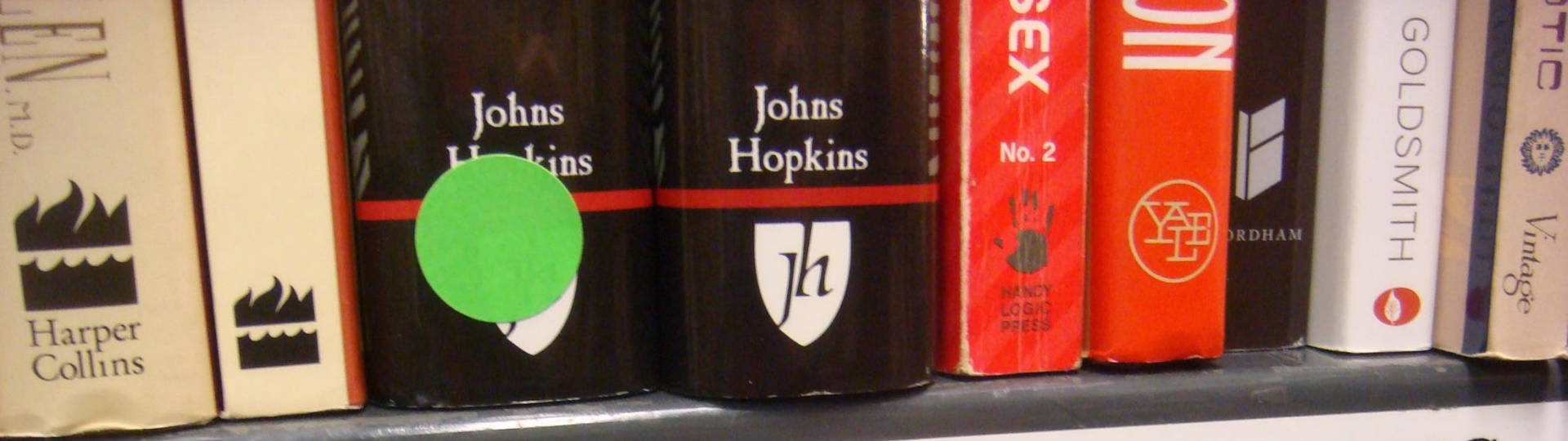
- placenta birthed
- Birthing parent and baby evaluated (Apgar scores at 1 min and 5 min)
- Caesarian ('C section') birth may be scheduled, or required



BIRTHING CHOICES IN BC

- Hospital birth with an obstetrician or family physician (most labour support will be from L&D nurses)
- Midwife-attended birth (at home or in hospital)
- Doula support is optional, for a fee





SEXUALITY CONTINUES



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